

Discord Redesign Phase 1

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Abstract— Over the past eight years since its initial release date, Discord has become a prevalent communication social platform in which countless people use on a daily basis. The main functionalities of Discord include instant messaging, voice calls, and video calls for individuals and groups. The main task that I will be discussing involves Discord's group voice channels for group users.

1 PROBLEM SPACE

Discord's user base is constantly growing and expanding every year. The platform's annual registered users has jumped from 25 million in 2016 to 656 million in 2023 (Turner, 2022). With this fact in mind, the number of new users has grown exponentially. Although Discord's diverse functionality and reliability has helped it create great strides in gaining a loyal fanbase, its interface design is severely lacking in terms of user friendliness, especially towards new users. Group voice channels is one of the main functionalities that Discord offers to its consumers; however, the interface that the users must use to be able to use this tool has not improved over the years.

1.1 Interface Design

Discord's current user interface consists of multiple grids that are lined up together from left to right with each box having a specific intended purpose. The second box from the left is the intended grid box for being able to navigate through text channels and voice channels. The group voice channels are designed to be listed from top to bottom so that the user can see all the available channels that others have created. Through this same list of channels the user can join the voice channel of his or her choosing.

1.1.1 Visuals

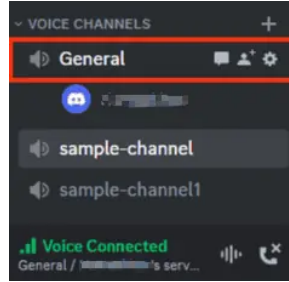


Figure 1— Discord voice channel interface. Source: [Image1](#)

1.2 Environment

A majority of users utilizing discord has the main task of communicating with other people, whether its on a call, instant messaging, or webcam. Most people use Discords on a computer while there is also another option of using Discord app on their phones. With the main purpose of communication, Discord is typically used in conjunction with other tasks that the user may be completing on his or her computer.

1.3 Interface conflicts

With any type of application, once a user becomes familiar with the technology then any user unfriendliness becomes more manageable. Nevertheless, Discord's voice channels causes new users a great deal of confusion when trying to first utilize the tool. To be able to join any of the voice chats that a user desires, they would simply have to click on the name of the voice channel. This automatically has the user enter the voice channel and his or her name will be displayed under the channel name. The issue is that if a new user is going through this design for the first time they would not know that this step is required to achieve their task. When a user hovers over the voice channel name, the voice channel is highlighted and two buttons of open chat and create invite are displayed. This inturn would give the user the impression that they only have two options while hovering over the voice channel. The hidden option of joining the channel by clicking on the voice channel's name is completely unknown to any new user. Another issue that new users may come across is how to leave a voice channel. To leave a channel, the user must click on the phone icon with an "X" at the bottom of the screen. With this function in such an obscure location and no

explicit indication that this button is to leave a voice channel, users will have no way to end a voice channel call when desired.

2 USER TYPES

Even though Discord started out as an application designed for gamers, it has spread to a broader audience utilizing it for school, communication, and even work.

2.1 Main Users

The average age range for Discord users are between 18-34 years old, which consists of over 70% of its total user population. In addition, Discord's main users consists of 79.46% males (HeadphonesAddict, 2022). This shows that a majority of Discord users are young to middle aged males. It's most common uses include school, messaging, and gaming. Approximately 78% of Discord users use this application for many uses besides its intended use for gaming (HeadphonesAddict, 2022).

3 PARTICIPANT OBSERVATION

Experiencing the task itself will be used to gather data on the task of utilizing Discord's voice channels. I will be following specific steps to complete the task multiple times to gather data in many contexts.

3.1 Steps

The first step to the participant observation will to determine the environmental factors. Since I will be repeating the task multiple times I will be changing my physical location each time. In addition, I will vary the physical use of Discord by using different devices such as computer, tablet, and phone to determine if device affects the data collected. The next step will be to access Discord. With access to Discord complete, I will then choose a preexisting voice channel I have access to and join the channel. To join the channel I would click on the name of the voice channel on the list of channels. Once the call is connected, a display will show that I am inside the channel and I will leave the call. The main goal will be to complete a voice channel call. Since this can be completed with no other person needed I will simply join a voice channel and leave the voice channel.

3.2 Data Collection

The data that will be collected through this process will directly intertwined with the data inventory. With multiple participations in utilizing Discord's voice channels, I am able to determine where I am and in what context will I be using Discord. In addition, my goals of utilizing Discord will be clear. Following the steps I will also be able to determine the overall task and each subtask as well. The observations from participating in the activity will give me a personal view of how users will be interacting with the interface.

3.3 Potential Bias

The main bias that can stem from participant observation during the needfinding is confirmation bias and recall bias. Due to the fact that I am an experienced Discord user, my conclusions from the data that I will be collecting can be inherently biased from my personal opinions. In addition, recall bias can impact the needfinding as well since my prior experiences with Discord can affect the participation steps. There could possibly be shortcuts or hacking that I subconsciously add into the steps that a new user may not know. To combat the issues that confirmation bias and recall bias can cause, I will be breaking down all the steps in the participation to its most finite actions possible and follow each step as a new user. This will allow me to observe every single interaction between myself and the interface itself.

4 SURVEYS

Discord has a large variety of users that can range from male to female and young to old. Utilizing surveys, I will be gathering data from a diverse group of participants to be able to collect a broader range of data from users. Even though the data will not be as thorough as interviews, I will be able to gather a larger amount of data to be examined.

4.1 Questions

The design of the survey will follow a very specific guideline to allow the participants to give the most amount of opinions on Discord and how they are utilizing the application. The questions to survey will include a few questions about the demographics of the user. This allows me to be able to know who the user is and be able to draw conclusions based on contextual evidence of the user's environment, such as age and sex. The length of time the user has used

Discord will also be important to collect. The survey will then move onto questions that move the questions towards the use of Discord and whether the user uses similar types of applications. The survey will also include questions such that the user clearly lists what the user is using the application for and how it is able to assist them in completing the task. The user will then be asked to explain what they use Discord for and why they use Discord for one task over using another application for the same task. Next, the user will be asked to judge his or her satisfaction of using Discord and explain why they have chosen his or her satisfaction level.

4.2 Survey Participants

The survey participants will be gathered from a large variety of users. The only strict requirement is that the user must have used Discord at least once. If the user has never used Discord before then they will not have any opinions or experience in how the application works and will not be able to properly offer any data to the existing interface. The survey participants will be sent to as wide range of participants as possible through online community forums. This will ensure that no personal connections or bias can influence the participants. In addition, the participants will be able to maintain anonymity and express their true opinions of the application.

4.3 Potential Bias

Observer bias can be found in surveys due to the phrasing of questions. Careful consideration of what type of questions and how the questions are worded can help reduce this problem. Following the guidelines of creating survey questions, I created survey questions that does not indicate any specific answers that I am looking for which allows the user to give more honest opinions. Recall bias is also a likelihood that may arise when working with surveys. This is due to the context the participants will be answering. The users completing the surveys may not be users who use Discord on a daily basis or has not used Discord in a long time. This can cause the user to incorrectly judge his or her opinions and give answers that are not accurate. To help filter out these users, one of the questions will be determining how often the user uses Discord. This will help determine whether or not recall bias will be affecting the data.

5 ANALYSIS OF REVIEWS

With such a large user population of Discord and other similar applications, an analysis of the reviews that users have had is one of the needfinding methods I will utilize.

5.1 Examination of Reviews

To lower potential bias that will be discussed further ahead, the process of the examination of the reviews will strictly be adhering to specific rules. The reviews that will be examined will be only of products that has the exact same functionality that was discussed, which is group voice chatting. All of the reviews will be pulled from “getapp.com”, which gives users the ability to post ratings and reviews on digital applications. By centralizing all the reviews to come from one location, the population that the reviews are coming from will be minimized to specific users of that application. In addition, only reviews within the last year will be considered, which will restrict the high number of reviews examined. Once all the reviews have been gathered, a final filtering of the reviews to remove any extreme bias reviews or reviews with unsupported claims will be done to ensure that the final examination of the reviews will result in the most accurate data collected possible.

5.2 Review Process

Once the list of reviews have been gathered, the main comparison between Discord and other applications will be done using the reviews. Through the use of the reviews, I want to be able to determine whether the applications were able to complete the user’s goals. In addiiton, what are the tasks and subtasks that the user must go through to achieve his or her goal. With each application, the users’ purpose can vary from school to leisure. This also brings up who the users are and how does one application differ from another in assisting the user in completing his or her goal.

5.3 Potential Bias

Voluntary response bias and confirmation bias are the possible biases that can come up when working with product reviews for Discord and other similar applications. With millions of users and thousands of reviews, the impact of voluntary response bias may be lessened. However, since this bias comes from optional reviews of the user population, the potential of the data being affected is

still prevalent. Confirmation bias is also a possibility when collecting data through the product reviews. Since I personally already have my opinions on the issues that Discord currently has, the examination of the reviews can be altered based on my examination. I could be focusing more towards positive or negative reviews or towards issues that I agree with. To combat this, I will randomly be extracting a set amount of reviews from Discord and other similar applications over the past year. This process will also involve filtering out possible extreme reviews or unsupported reviews with no explanations. This will allow me to properly examine reviews that offers data to be collected while also minimizing any bias that may arise.

6 REFERENCES

1. HeadphonesAddict. (2022, November 7). 39+ *Discord Statistics: Users, Servers, Demographics, Revenue*(2023).
<https://headphonesaddict.com/discord-users/#::~:~:text=An%20average%20Discord%20user%20is>
2. Turner, A. (2022, March 1). *Discord Users: How Many People Use Discord* (Apr2023).BankMyCell.
<https://www.bankmycell.com/blog/number-of-discord-users/>

7 APPENDIX

Survey interview questions:

- What is your gender?
 - Male
 - Female
- What is your age range?
 - 0 - 18
 - 18 - 35
 - 35 - 45
 - 45 - 60
 - 60+
- How long have you been using Discord?
 - 0 - 3 months
 - 4 -11 months

- 1 - 2 years
 - 2+ years
- How often do you use Discord?
 - Daily
 - A few times a week
 - A few times a month
 - Has not used Discord in over a month
- What other voice calling social platform do you use besides Discord?
 - Facebook
 - Skype
 - Microsoft Teams
 - Zoom
 - GoogleHangouts
 - Others (Please list all) _____
- What is the main reason you use Discord?
 - Gaming
 - Social communication
 - Work
 - Others (Please list all) _____
- Per the previous question, please explain why you use Discord over another application?
 - _____
- Rate your satisfaction in using Discord?
 - Highly Dissatisfied
 - Dissatisfied
 - Neutral
 - Satisfactory
 - Highly Satisfactory
- Rate your satisfaction in using Discord's voice calling?
 - Highly Dissatisfied
 - Dissatisfied
 - Neutral
 - Satisfied
 - Highly Satisfied
- Rate your satisfaction in using Discord's voice channels?
 - Highly Dissatisfied
 - Dissatisfied

- Neutral
 - Satisfactory
 - Highly Satisfactory
- Please comment any improvements or issues you have with Discord
 - _____